

Course Code and Name: MSJ1201 – Communication Research

Project Name: Research Proposal

Semester: Spring 2023

Project Description: During the Spring 2023 semester, my group and I prepared a research proposal for the course MSJ1201: Communication Research at the University of Liberal Arts Bangladesh (ULAB). The study, titled "Exploring the Reasons of Bangladeshi Students' Apprehension and Its Impact During and After University Admission," examined the causes of fear and anxiety among university admission candidates and their effects on students' mental health. Using a qualitative approach with semi-structured interviews and cluster sampling, we aimed to collect students' personal experiences from different regions of Bangladesh. The research also reviewed previous studies, national statistics, and news reports to better understand admission-related stress. The project proposed practical insights to help families, educational institutions, and society reduce admission pressure and promote a healthier attitude toward higher education.

Project Justification: This research focuses on the mental health challenges faced by Bangladeshi students during the highly competitive university admission process. It explores how limited public university seats, family expectations, and social pressure contribute to fear, anxiety, and emotional stress among admission candidates. I chose this topic because these issues affect thousands of students each year but often receive little attention. The study aims to raise awareness and provide insights that can help families, educators, and policymakers create a more supportive and less stressful admission environment.



ULAB

UNIVERSITY OF LIBERAL ARTS BANGLADESH

Department of Media Studies and Journalism

COURSE NAME: Communication Research

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SECTION:02

Research Proposal On
Exploring the Reasons of Bangladeshi
Students Apprehension and Its Impact During and After University Admission

Submitted To

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Title: “Exploring the Reasons of Bangladeshi Students Apprehension and Its Impact during and after University Admission”

1. Introduction

1.1. Focus Idea:

Among the current issues, university admission apprehension has become one of the common issues among the Bangladeshi students. Every year after the HSC examination, there starts a fierce competition among the students of all over the Bangladesh for university entrance exam. There are so many students, families and also peoples of society who take this exam as the biggest battle of life and as a result some students become unable to accept their failure of their desirable university. And these things are occurring for many reasons. The main focus of this research will be to find out the reasons of the apprehension among the candidates of Bangladesh about university admission and also point out the impacts on the students during and after admission period. Among the current issues, university admission apprehension has become one of the common issues among the Bangladeshi students. Every year after the HSC examination, there starts a fierce competition among the students of all over the Bangladesh for university entrance exam. There are so many students, families and also peoples of society who take this exam as the biggest battle of life and as a result some students become unable to accept their failure of their desirable university. And these things are occurring for many reasons.

The main focus of this research will be to find out the reasons of the apprehension among the candidates of Bangladesh about university admission and also point out the impacts on the students during and after admission period.

1.2. Background:

University admission apprehension and its impact on the students are quite noticeable nowadays. There we can see much news, articles on this issue that students who failed to get their desirable university are suffering from long term depression and as a result some students chose the path of suicide.

As example, there published a news in Dhaka Tribune about a student who sat for medical entrance exam live in Mugda, Dhaka, couldn't make her seat for medical and as a result she committed suicide by jumping off a rooftop (Student commits suicide, 2021).

Behind these things' family members, peoples of society and also peer are responsible for their misconceptions which they used to put on the students' mind about universities and some other thoughts.

1.3. Topic Relevance:

According to Bangladesh Education Statistics 2021, there are 51,152 first-year student seats available at 49 public universities, and 11,30,032 at the National University. 2,38,323 first-year student places are available at 107 private universities (Akhter, 2023). And there are millions of students who fought for university entrance exam and many of them also had to struggle with anxiety, depression. But not everybody expresses their feelings to others and also the other people couldn't aware about these issues.

Therefore, the purpose of this research is to find out the reasons that are pushing the students into apprehensive condition and their impacts on the students.

1.4. Research Objectives:

The present study seeks to investigate the reasons of apprehension and its impact on Bangladeshi university admission candidates. The specific objectives of the study are:

- To find out the reasons for anxiety among the students.
- To investigate how the family, society, peers and other things are becoming a reason for this fear during the admission period.
- To investigate the impact of the apprehension on the admission candidates.
- To examine how the candidates are going through in the admission preparation period.

1.5. The questions that this research will be answering are:

- What are the most prominent reasons that are creating this fear in students generally?
- What effect does the university admission apprehension have on the admission candidates?
- What will be the procedures to measure the rates of anxiety among the university admission candidates?
- What are the factors that are creating misconceptions about universities among family, society and others which are affecting the students before and even after the university admission?
- What methods will be useful for doing this research and how it will play a significant role in the future?

1.6. Scopes and Limitations of the Research

1.6.1. Scopes-

- Necessary paces can be taken to remove the apprehension or fear or long-term depressions from the students.
- Families and others can be cautious in making any kind of university admission-related decisions for their children.
- Also, it can be helpful to eliminate the misconceptions between public and private from family, society and even everyone.

1.6.2. Limitations-

- Not everyone will be comfortable to share their experiences in detail.
- Not everyone will be able to collaborate frequently with our procedure or someone will try to avoid some questions.
- Not everyone will give the actual information. Sometimes they may make mistakes in giving any delicate information

2.0. Literature Review

This part of this research provides the key concepts by highlighting some relevant researches that have been conducted before in the previous times.

2.1. Title – “Suicidal Behaviors and University Entrance Test-Related Factors: A Bangladeshi Exploratory Study”

On this research, Mamun et al. (2022) conducted a study on Bangladeshi students’ suicidal behaviors and university entrance exam related factors. They investigate the unexplored psychological facts of the students in university entrance test and tried to point out the measurements of anxiety, burnout, depression and suicidal behaviors with statistical analysis on this research.

Methodology: It is a quantitative approach which has conducted through questionnaire survey in Jahangirnagar University among the test taking students who were living there during the exam period (September 22-October 1, 2019).

Findings: Suicidal thoughts are reported by about 17.7% of participants, compared to suicide plans and attempts which are reported by 8.0% and 2.5% of participants, respectively. Although the suicide plan and suicide attempts are unrelated to student position, repeat test-takers showed remarkably higher suicidal thought than first time test-takers (20.7% 14.6%, $t=5.669$, $p=0.017$). The risk factors for suicidal thoughts include being a woman, living in a city, like the mock test having mental illness and so on.

2.2. Title – “Burnout, Does the University Entrance Test Failing Attribute? A Bangladeshi Exploratory Study”

Mamun et al. (2021) researched on the university entrance test failing attribute that burnout or anxiety are the reasons or not and it is a Bangladeshi study. They try to find out the measurements of psychological issues like burnout for academic non-achievement in student’s initial effort. Also, they look into the previous research on estimating population burnout. Through investigation they find out the rate of students’ burnout in university entrance test for academic non-achievement.

Methodology: It is a quantitative approach which has conducted at Jahangirnagar University, Savar, Dhaka during the university entrance exam.

Findings: The results of this research support the hypothesis that students who take tests repeatedly are more likely to experience burnout with physical variables acting as major contributing potential factor according to the MBI-SS's two- and three-dimensional cutoff method, respectively 43.7% and 17.3% of test taken were labeled as burnout in the overall population. Additionally, the overall group of students indicated greater levels of emotional exhaustion, higher cynicism and lower academic efficacy. In terms of student status, repeat test - takers had substantially greater rates of two-dimensional burnout (48.0% vs 39.2%, $2=7.164$, $P=0.007$) and emotional exhaustion (52.2% vs 43.9%, $2=6.789$, $p=.034$)

2.3. Title – “Academic Expectations Stress in Asian American Undergraduate Students –Asian American Undergraduate Students and Perceived Academic Competition” (I)

This research intended to investigate how Asian American undergraduate students evaluate their academic triumphs and inadequacies in relation to other Asian American undergraduate students in their peer group. This research attempted to comprehend the educational pressures that Asian American students face as a result of perceived academic rivalry with other Asian American classmates, as well as how the enforcement to perform academically impacts their general welfare, self-regard, and mental stability.

Methodology This qualitative research project has used an interpretive paradigm, with assumptions that reality is constructed through acknowledging about self and others, knowledge and findings emerge with investigation, and reinterpretation and bargaining are possible with interpretation. This methodology fits with the way that focus groups were used in this research to collect data. Focus groups are helpful for examining the perception of academic competition, acquiring background data, and developing study hypotheses based on participant replies. In contrast to one-on-one interviews, which would have required many dates and times to conduct, focus groups allowed the researcher to examine an interesting issue with a variety of perspectives all at once. Due to time restrictions, focus groups were the most effective way to collect information.

Findings: After analyzing the replies from the two focus groups of Asian American college students, eight themes came to light. These are the themes:

- 1) Increased perceiving intellectual competitiveness in high school owing to closeness of Asian students;
- 2) Slighter pressure in college, particularly in fields where Asian students are underrepresented;
- 3) Feel greater pressure from parents in high school owing to proximity and less pressure from parents in college due to distance;

- 4) Internalizing parental expectations so that self-imposed pressure to do well;
- 5) comparing one's own academic achievements to those of family members or friends' children frequently;
- 6) A sense of debt to one's parents, which increases pressure to achieve.

2.4. Title – “Academic Expectations Stress in Asian American Undergraduate Students – Academic Expectations Inventory” (II)

On this study, Nguyen & Huynh (2015) held research on American undergraduate students on academic expectation stress. They look into whether the AESI two-factor model was appropriate for Asian American college students by focusing on the themes of academic enforcement and internalization of family expectations.

Methodology: It is a qualitative research approach. The PI sent an email and IRB authorized email asking professors to help with data collection and providing a brief summary of the study. They also researched the variant categories of Asian American student associations applying the Student Activities website to identify 17 potential cultural student organizations for recruitment. Academic Expectations Stress Inventory (AESI).

Findings: According to this study, students who are under a lot of academic pressure are more prone to have psychological problems like melancholy and anxiety, worry about getting bad grades, and daily inconveniences and pressures. The findings imply that Asian American college students can use all nine of the AESI's components. Tan and Yates (2011) discovered that students from Confucian Heritage Culture may be assessed for academic stress using the AESI. According to the study's findings, there are no variations in academic stress from parents or teachers between Asian American male and female college students when it comes to their levels of academic expectations. This is the line with recent research on how Asian American college students internalize their parents' expectations and how this influences their own academic goals.

2.5. Title – “Stress Impact on Applicants Trying to Gain Entrance to Public Universities”

On this research, Medina & Allier (2012) conducted a study on stress impact on the students who are trying to gain entrance in public universities. They find out the pressure on youth applicants who try to public universities and how they feel during the admission period. Also, they investigate the measurement of the anxiety level during the admission process. Moreover, they try to find out the difference of anxiety among boys and girls which is affected by the test results.

Methodology: It is a quantitative approach conducted through a survey to evaluate several areas of stress management and academic progress. Using the use of a 12-item survey questionnaire, data was gathered. Using a Likert-style scale, students were asked to score

each issue according to their consideration. The questionnaire also includes open-ended questions to encourage students to provide in-depth responses, in addition to asking them to score each item. Students received questionnaires twice throughout the course that included a variety of questions regarding how stressed they felt about previous tests, their fear of failing, and their potential for becoming NiNi (Neither studying, nor working).

Findings: The results of a questionnaire were gathered from 79 youth enrolled in a course trying to gain entrance to college, with 37 females and 35 males ranging in age from 17 to 24. Twelve questions were included in the questionnaire. Results showed that girls were more likely than boys to report worrisome levels, likely due to low self-esteem. Girls also scored slightly higher than boys on the grade average obtained in high school, and had to repeat the admission test several times. This study found that 25 students out of 59 who took the admissions test were accepted into the school. Four students felt exam anxiety, while the other pupils felt little to no worry. There was some agreement on the explanations to explain the potential causes of their failure in prior tests, such as chance or external factors. Instructors should talk to pupils about building self-esteem and encouraging them to be more persistent in their academic efforts.

3.0. Research Design

3.1. Research Approach and Methodology

It's a qualitative approach which follows up the method of in-depth interview.

As we want to capture an accurate, in-depth insights through this research, that's why we select qualitative approach. It is very helpful to gather factual data. On the other hand, there can be some students who will not be willing to share their own experiences with others or wanted to keep them secret. For this reason, we choose the in-depth interview method so that we can talk to our selected participants efficiently with time through a friendly conversation.

3.2. Sampling

Our target population for this research is those who are the recent university admission candidates and recently attended their university admission exam. In Bangladesh there are eight divisions where millions of people live. So, we want to collect some participants from every division by dividing them in some areas according to our participants' collection requirements who are the university admission candidates. That's the reason behind choosing this sampling method. The sampling method of this research mentioned bellow will be as followed:

Cluster Sampling: In-depth Interview-

The goal of our current study is to look into the causes of apprehension and how it affects the university candidates of Bangladesh. The research will specifically be done in the areas of Dhaka city. An in-depth interview in a semi- structured process will be upheld with the

selected participants, so that we can have their noted experiences according to our objectives through an ordinary conversation. The participants will be motivated to share their experiences fluently. The interview will be led by the following ways:

- Organize an interview through offline and online both which is suitable for the particular.
- Prepare interview questionnaire.
- Take notes of their responses and if any additional information and experience.
- Pointing out the common reasons from each participant's speech.

3.3. Timeframe

Bangladesh has total eight divisions and, in each division, there live around million of peoples. So, we need to reach out our selected areas for data collection and depending on its distance we will need approximately 20 days. For background information it will take 5 days and for literature review it can take the same time. After collecting every component for processing and analyzing them it will take minimum 7 days and again for the final result it will take 3 days. So, all in all it can be said that it may take approximately total 40 days to complete this research properly.

3.4. Budgeting

Below is a complete budget list of what the research might cost –

- For resources like books, journals, publications and others will be cost around 1000 BDT.
- Stationary components like papers, photocopy or printing, pen etc will take 1000 BDT.
- Operational costs will take around 50,000 BDT.
- In case of transportation cost it will take around 30,000 BDT.
- Remunerations for data collectors will take 15,000 BDT.
- Miscellaneous 5000 BDT.

So, in total, this research can cost 102,000 BDT.

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Project Learnings and Outcomes: This project strengthened my academic research skills by improving my ability to develop research questions, objectives, and research plans. It enhanced my understanding of research methods, data collection, and literature review while increasing my knowledge of mental health and academic pressure among university admission candidates in Bangladesh. The project also improved my critical thinking, analytical, and communication skills, helping me become a more responsible and ethical communication researcher.